

Work, Recalculated

CORE WORKFORCE SEGMENT

By 2025, India's Gen Z population stood at an estimated 377 million, accounting for 25% of the workforce. This is projected to rise to 36% by 2030 and 47% by 2035, signalling a deep structural shift (BCG-Snapchat)

PAY AND PROGRESSION STILL TOP PRIORITY

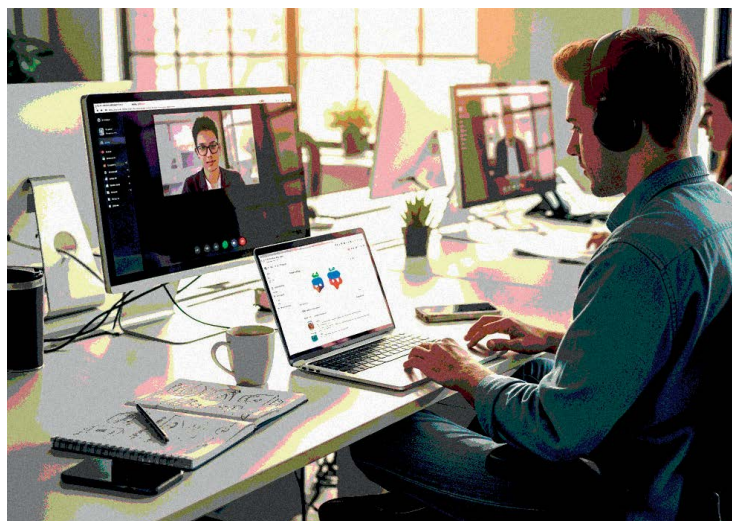
Salary growth and financial security (28%) and career progression (28%) remain Gen Z's leading job drivers. Job security (17%) matters most to lower-income cohorts, while work-life balance (14%) and flexibility (9%) gain importance with financial stability. (BT-PRICE)

MODERN WORK BEHAVIOURS ARE WIDESPREAD

75% of employees have adopted at least one modern work behaviour such as job-hopping, flexible schedules, side hustles, or quiet quitting. Yet 42% of employers view these as disengagement, while 62% of employees see them as pragmatic (Indeed)

ACTIVELY EXPERIMENTING EARLY IN CAREER

Nearly 68% of entry- to junior-level employees are testing new learning and career models, with around 40% blending full-time work with side hustles, flexible hours, or short career breaks (Indeed)



REDEFINING CAREER, NOT ABANDONING AMBITION

43% of Gen Zs prefer a full-time role with a side hustle, while only 16% want a single-track career. Although

38% of Zoomers plan to stay in their current role for less than a year, 94% evaluate jobs based on their long-term goals. (Randstad's 'The GenZ Workplace Blueprint' Report)

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likely to build cultures where people choose to stay, grow, and contribute meaningfully.

The findings also show that attempting to restrict these behaviours does not eliminate them, it merely pushes them underground, making them harder for organisations to address constructively. At the same time, attrition has increased by 11%.

Crucially, the data reveals that employees who feel empowered to evolve their skills and work approaches demonstrate a higher intent to stay. Interpreting flexibility, experimentation, and autonomy as threats risks alienating the talent or-

ganisations are trying to retain.

Yet despite mounting evidence, many Indian organisations continue to struggle with execution.

While many Indian employers believe they understand Gen Z, execution often tells a different story. According to Careernet's Das, the gap lies in persistence with legacy hiring and management models. Zoomers place far less value on fixed structures and formal hierarchies and far more on speed, transparency, and responsiveness.

Slow hiring cycles, limited digital interaction, and delayed clarity around role progression or compensation can quickly erode trust.

Randstad's research shows that pay, flexible hours, and work-life balance are significantly stronger retention drivers for Gen Z than traditional perks.

To stay relevant, Das argues, annual appraisals must give way to continuous, coaching-led feedback, and performance systems need to be redesigned around skills and learning. Managers must be trained in emotional intelligence and developmental leadership, while flexibility must be embedded into systems.

REALITY CHECK

"Let's be honest... being Gen Z in today's corporate world isn't easy.